

had borrowed so much money from the bank that I was not even eligible for a loan. My wife worked in the same bank and she managed to take a loan of Rs 5.5 lakh and fund the project," he adds pointing to a house—originally designed to be his home—built from the debris of demolished houses in Mangalore, Kerala and Tamil Nadu. It was a showcase for the best of south Indian architecture. His creation was

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NOY, Conservationist



SANJAY RAMCHANDRAN

so marvellous that visitors poured in from every corner. "We used to get people till late night, wanting to look at the house. Soon I realised that this cannot belong to me alone. It belongs to the nation," he says. So the man, who has created 26 such structures so far, became homeless by choice.

Enthused by the great public response to his humble house, Shenoy thought of blowing up the same profile on a wider canvas in subtle colours and elegant lines in the form of a heritage village. One of the buildings recreated in the village, now known as the Hasta Shilpa Kala's Heritage Village, is a 100-year-old ancestral house belonging to a Shivalli Brahmin family. The house does not have a single nail or screw, not even a hinge holding the doors together. It reflects the ingenuity of the builders who fixed doors and windows on a swivel.

Shenoy's work involves identification of demolished or to-be-demolished houses, documenting them extensively, and transplanting them "without a single change in their form". Besides these 26 structures, the village also hosts a K.K. Hebbar museum, a Tanjore paintings museum, a Raja Ravi Varma museum and a folk museum with sculptures that are over 1,000 years old. The variety in architecture is overwhelming—from a century-old palace of the Adil Shahi Kingdom to the Bassel Mission, a Christian missionary society that operates around the world, and a Mangalorean Christian heritage structure.

"What is architecture but a slice of history in physical form, a feast of the richness and glory of bygone days? We can't allow it to be destroyed," says Shenoy. One can't help agreeing as one walks along the bazaar street he has created with shops displaying old locks, umbrellas and lamps. "I also collected hundreds of artefacts in metal, stone, wood, cane and other mediums and put them on display in their appropriate places in respective houses restructured in the Heritage Village," he says. His treasure trove, once open, will be a unique heritage showcase, unlike museums, where you can see but not touch. "People must feel history breathing within these walls," he says.

Shenoy's work is partly supported by the Volkart Foundation as well as the embassies of Norway, Finland and the Netherlands. "There have been days when there was no money to pay the staff. But the project took care of itself. It has grown beyond me now," he says. Yes, as a historical corridor connecting the past with the future. ■